



CHAPTER XVI

THE UTAH WAR 1857 – 1858

Under a territorial form of government, an inevitable antagonism developed between a people so different as the Saints and the government appointees sent into the Utah Territory. Even under favorable circumstances the Mormons had been a people little understood. The Mormons were devoted primarily to the church of which they were members and were suspicious of a government which had either been unable or unwilling to protect them. The large majority of the Saints were of foreign birth and preferred the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints to all else in life. The Government appointees were outsiders who were very different from the Saints. The law of God was more important to the Mormons than the law of the land, although the Saints were loyal subjects as long as the policies of the Government did not interfere with their beliefs.¹ This attitude probably had an effect on the early applications of the people of Utah for Statehood which were rejected by the Congress of the United States.

Prior to 1856 the United States Government had defended the right of the territories to determine for themselves the domestic problems of slavery. They also defended the right of a territory to determine for itself the domestic problems of marriage. However, during the assembly of Congress in Philadelphia on June 17, 1856, the

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Republican platform compared the doctrine of "plural marriage" to "slavery," and they adopted a decided stand against the Mormons. It was resolved that the constitution gave Congress power over the territories of the United States and that it was the right and the duty of Congress to prohibit both polygamy and slavery.

The Chief Justice of the Utah Territory prior to 1854 was Lazarus H. Reed, of New York. He and his associates were well received and became highly respected by the Mormon people. Leonidas Shaver was the associate justice. With the resignation of Chief Justice Reed in 1854, John F. Kinney was appointed in his stead and proved an honest and impartial judge, honored and esteemed by Mormon and non-Mormon alike. But in 1855 there came to Utah as associate justices two men who were to arouse the resentment of the Saints and eventually cost the United States government forty million dollars. One was Judge William W. Drummond who replaced Judge Zerubbabel Snow, whose term of office had expired. The other was George P. Stiles, A Mormon apostate who replaced Judge Shaver who had died.

Drummond was an immoral and unprincipled man. He left his wife and children without support in his own state of Illinois and appeared in Utah accompanied by a woman whom he introduced as his wife, and who often sat upon the bench with him. His drunken and dissolute habits caused the Saints to despise him and their feelings were ill-concealed. Later, when his immorality and neglect of his own family were revealed, he left the territory in disgrace. The churning debate over federal control of Utah came to a head in 1855 with Drummond's ill-timed appointment to the Territorial Bench. No figure in the development of the Utah War proved to be more troublesome to the Saints than did this unknown Midwestern attorney, and no man expended more effort working for Brigham Young's downfall. Even after his resignation from office he continued to spread a multitude of false accusations against the Saints.²

If it could be made to appear that the Mormons were in rebellion against the United States, the danger of Utah as a new "free state" would be inevitably postponed, whether the facts supported that view or not. Outsiders, therefore, eagerly seized upon the charges of

Drummond. An investigation was neither desired, nor made, for fear that the true state of affairs might be exposed.

The president of the United States, James Buchanan decided to settle the Mormon question by appointing not only a new governor, but also a complete slate of non-Mormon officials who were to be escorted into the territory by the army. "All Hell appears to be wide awake against us," wrote George A. Smith to Brigham Young, "the press is doing its wickedest. Drummond is one of the most popular men in the nation at present." With these words still echoing in his mind, Brigham Young weighed three possible courses of action: stand and fight, allow the army to occupy the territory, or abandon the territory to the army, leaving behind the labor of ten years.³ The difficulty of communication in those days and the isolation of the Saints in the Utah valleys made it possible for the "Army" to be well under way to the West before the Utah people became aware of it.

Preparations for "war" however, went quietly forward. Under the date of August 1, 1857, General Wells reported the approach of an army to invade Utah to the officers and men of the Nauvoo Legion. He instructed the district commanders to hold their respective divisions of the militia in readiness to march at the shortest possible notice to any part of the territory. Word was sent throughout the settlements to conserve the grain supply, to use none for the feeding of cattle, and to sell none to emigrant trains for that purpose. Nearly all elders on missions were recalled. Samuel W. Richards was dispatched with instructions to Orson Pratt and Ezra T. Benson in the British Mission. En route he delivered a letter to Colonel Thomas L. Kane, addressed to President Buchanan protesting against the actions of the government. The message delivered was a harsh arraignment of the government and a brief history of the treatment of the Mormons at the hands of the government from the beginning of the Missouri troubles.⁴

The people in the outlying settlements of San Bernardino, California, Carson, Nevada, and on the Salmon River in Idaho, were ordered to dispose of their property and return to Salt Lake Valley. The dispatch and spirit with which the Saints in those settlements carried out the orders of Brigham Young, sacrificed their homes and

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journeyed to Salt Lake Valley ready to die with the Saints rather than submit to further persecution, is one of the finest examples of the unity and faith of the Mormon people. The attitude was maintained throughout by the Mormon leaders that, with the help of the Lord, the Saints could successfully resist the United States Army. In the face of the reports of the army expedition they received, the Saints naturally expected the worst. Repeatedly they had been driven until there was no further place to flee. They decided to resist further persecution to the last drop of their blood.

In the meantime Captain Van Vliet, the advance courier of the "Army," arrived in Salt Lake City in September and met with the leading Church authorities in the old Social Hall on September 9, 1857. Van Vliet assured the church leaders that the army was not coming to make war, but they were not convinced. The Captain was courteously informed that no hostile army would be allowed to enter the Territory. Federal officers would be welcomed without troops, if they came in peace.⁵

Henry was informed of the controversy during his long interview with Brigham Young after his return from England, even to the massacre by Indians and others at Mountain Meadows near Cedar City. Henry's company had observed and passed army troops on the Missouri River in June and heard the boasts in August of four thousand troops at "Horseshoe Creek." As a result, he and President Young had much to talk about concerning the fate of the Saints and what part Henry Lunt would play in the upcoming problems, as well as what the leaders were intending to do to thwart an all-out war.

When Henry was still in Salt Lake City on October 4, 1857, instructions were given to the Utah Militia Officers to annoy the oncoming troops in any way and to use every means to harass them, even to burning the whole country before them if needed. Fort Bridger and Fort Supply, then owned by the Church, were burned to the ground to prevent their being utilized by the United States Army. Before leaving Fort Bridger, General Wells sent Major Lot Smith, with a small company of men, to intercept the supply trains then advancing from South Pass. Major Smith was remarkably successful in his mission and destroyed an immense quantity of supplies intended

for the Army. From his successive raids, 1,000 head of cattle were driven into Salt Lake Valley from the army encampments.⁶ Much of this had taken place before Henry left for Cedar City on October 11, 1857. It was a sixteen-day trip to Cedar Fort. On Sunday, November 1, Henry reported his mission in church. The agenda of the church meeting held that day follows: "Sunday meeting opened by singing. Opening prayer by Bishop P. K. Smith. Elder Henry Lunt, as of late from his mission to England, gave an account of his mission."⁷

The general unrest throughout the Great Basin was expressed by George A. Smith, as recorded in the *L.D.S. Journal History* as follows (less than two months after the Mountain Meadow tragedy):

October 31, 1857: I visited the different settlements hurriedly until I reached Parowan. The 'Iron Battalion' had assembled together under the impression that their country was about to be invaded by the army from the United States. The Battalion was to make everything ready by preparing to strike in any direction and march to such places as might be necessary in the defense of their homes. They were willing any moment to touch fire to their homes and hide themselves in the mountains and to defend their country to the very last extremity. When I got to Cedar, I found the Battalions on parade. I preached a military discourse and told them in case of an invasion it might be necessary to set fire to our property and hide in the mountains and leave our enemies to do the best they could.

I went to Pinto and there addressed a house full of people in the evening and then proceeded to Cedar the next day. They had heard that an army was to come from the east into the town. The Major [in the Nauvoo Legion] seemed very sanguine about the matter. I asked him if that rumor should be true, if he was not going to wait for instructions? He replied 'there was no time to wait for any instructions' and he

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was going to take the Battalion and use them up before they could get down through the canyons. I am perfectly aware that in all settlements I visited in the south, Fillmore included, one single sentence is enough to put every man in motion; in fact, a word is enough to set in motion every man or set a torch to every building where the safety of this people is jeopardized.

In spite of the feeling of unrest, the settlers continued to carry on a normal life, even though the constant worry of the threats of the attack of Johnston's Army was on their minds. The Relief Society minutes documented the participation of Henry Lunt in their church meeting the first week of November:

Nov. 12, 1857: Sister Haight [Relief Society President] called for the teacher's report and then they sang the song, *The Spirit of God Like a Fire Is Burning*. Brother Lunt arose and said that it was with peculiar good feelings that, it being the first time that he had met with the sisters, that he perceived a marked improvement in the Saints in Cedar City, and that he felt as great an interest for the welfare of the Saints in the City now as much as he did when he left here in 1854, and that this Society was one of the best organizations in the Territory. He said that we ought to double our diligence and prepare our hearts for the times that are coming upon us for it will try the sisters to the very center. He spoke on the benefits arising from sisters teaching and visiting each other, thereby becoming acquainted, and that we were more united and stronger in faith than we were twelve months ago when this institution was first organized.

Sister Haight made some remarks on the poor, their want of clothing, etc. and said that if we would adopt every principle laid before us, a way would be opened that we knew not of, for their relief. Brother

Lunt then arose and prophesied in the name of the Lord that the saints in these mountains, who would live faithful, would have all the clothing they needed before long. Minutes taken by Ellen Lunt, Secretary

December 10, 1857: Relief Society Meeting. Bishop Smith spoke considerable on home manufacture etc. Brother Lunt made some very appropriate remarks. Spoke on cleanliness and many other principles of the Kingdom and said that the sisters would do well to adhere unto the counsel given by the Bishop.

It was moved and seconded that Mary Ann Lunt, Agnes Easton, Catherine Whittaker, and Louisa Hunt become members of this Society. Unanimous.⁸

The *New York Tribune* printed an article in Nov. 1857 which follows:

News from California. A word from Brigham Young is held in more respect by the Mormons than most weighty formal and solemn command from the President and Congress of the United States. What he orders is done, no matter what the order be. He ordered the Mormons in Carson Valley to move to Salt Lake City and they went. They had fine houses, fences, barns, orchards, gardens and fields and at the word, all these were sacrificed by men who had nothing to fear from refusal.

An exodus similar to that of Carson Valley is about to take place at San Bernardino. Cows worth \$100, at least, are selling there at \$25, and work oxen are sold for about half their value. The Mormons not only wish to get money for property which they cannot carry off, but they want money to buy arms and ammunition. The Mormon population of San Bernardino numbers 1,500 and, according to report, they are all to go. Those who are too poor to provide

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wagons for the convenience of their scanty provisions, cooking utensils, clothing and bedding, are to be furnished with wagons by the more wealthy, or are to be left behind and brought on by wagons which will be sent back.⁹

Henry continued to keep a journal after he returned home and made the following entries early in 1858:

Jan 29, 1858: I was appointed by the authorities of the Stake to go on a preaching mission to the settlements down south in Dixie, in company with some other brethren. We held meetings at Fort Harmony and Washington [called the Cotton Farm], some 30 miles distance from Harmony. There were some 30 families at this place. The climate very warm and pleasant. Saw several of the sisters wearing cloth from the cotton raised here. The next day we went to Santa Clara, an Indian Missionary Station. By request, I sang several songs. The next day we returned to Harmony. In the morning when we left Washington it was so warm for ten miles that we had to ride in our shirt sleeves, but before we got over the Black Ridge we encountered a severe snow storm with a heavy north wind, and it was with difficulty that we kept from freezing. I was so numbed when we got to Harmony that I could not dismount from the mule without assistance. Reached home in Cedar City on the 3rd of February where I stayed until I went to Parowan on the 13th.

March 30, 1858: The mail arrived from Salt Lake City and brought a circular containing instructions from President Brigham Young to the Saints. The main substance of the circular was to the effect that the Saints must leave Salt Lake City and all the settlements north and go as far as Provo for the

present and prepare their houses and improvements to be burned and laid in ashes, rather than the army should come in to enjoy them. The Saints in this and all the other southern settlements are called upon to send teams to assist in the removal of the poor families, the machinery, etc.

Isaac C. Haight wrote the following in his journal on Apr. 14, 1858:

Brother William H. Dame [Parowan Stake President] arrived, having been ordered from President Young to raise another company to go west to explore for a place to hide up from the face of our enemies. President Dame called upon me to raise fifteen men for the expedition. I called a meeting for this purpose and raised the required number of men and animals. We are building a new furnace.

May 8, 1858: We started our furnace this month but, for want of fuel and the lining giving way, we had to blow out [shut down].¹⁰

Early in 1858 the population of Cedar City was increased by the arrival of some of the settlers from San Bernardino, California, which place had been broken up by the saints the previous fall owing to the approach of the Johnston Army. Some of the brethren from Cedar City went out into the desert to help the California emigrants.¹¹ In the early spring of 1858 there were 30,000 exiles upon the slippery roads slowly leaving their homes in northern Utah and marching southward to await developments. Saints in the southern settlements furnished teams of horses and supplies with which to transport their brethren from the north to safer settlements. During that spring the incessant rain fell heavy on the exiles. Hundreds of poorly clad men and women and children walked ankle deep in heavy mud. Loaded wagons slid off the slippery roadbed and mired, axle deep, in the soft, untrampled clay. All important records of the church were taken to Provo where a temporary church office was established. Food supplies in the

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tithing office were sent to the southern settlements.

While marching with a company of Mormons who were returning from California to defend Zion, John R. Young related that they had scarcely entered Utah until they met parties of exiles fleeing southward to get beyond the reach of the unwelcome army. He said:

At Parowan, two hundred miles south of Salt Lake City, we encountered a scene that I shall never forget. I remember distinctly the exodus, as it was called, from Nauvoo when sixteen thousand souls left their homes and commenced that marvelous journey of fourteen hundred miles to the unknown valley of the Salt Lake. But that exodus was like a small rivulet by the side of a mighty river when compared with the seventy-five thousand men, women and children that we now met in one continuous line of travel. Horses, oxen and cows were harnessed or yoked to wagons and carts; mothers and children walked along moving the family's bunch of cows and flock of sheep, and all started on the journey to Sonora in Mexico.¹²

A great wave of sympathy swept the nation as the news spread abroad. Captain Van Vliet was impressed with the sincerity and orderliness of the Mormon people and felt convinced that the whole "Expedition" was a mistake. His report to the Secretary of War, delivered personally at Washington, D.C., opened the way for the sending of a peace commission. The climax came on June 7, 1858, when the peace commission, consisting of Lazarus W. Powell, late governor of Kentucky and Major Ben McCulloch of Texas reached Salt Lake City and was astonished to find so large a city with its inhabitants fled. Even the Church leaders had joined in the move south. The commission carried a proclamation of pardon with them, under the date of April 6, 1858, and granted a pardon to all who would submit to the authority of the federal government. Brigham Young declared that the Church leaders were not guilty of treason or rebellion, but would accept the pardon. Negotiations extended for

two or more weeks. President Young finally realized that neither war nor peace would stop the threat of federal control of Utah. The Saints accepted the Presidential proclamation of Amnesty and agreed to exchange their promise of loyalty for the guarantee that their lives and property would be protected by the army.

It was agreed that the Army would be allowed to pass through the city unmolested, providing they were not permitted to stop and would camp at least forty miles away. The Commission forwarded a letter to that effect to General Johnston, and on June 26, 1858, the Army passed through Salt Lake City and camped on the Jordan River. When the long army column entered Salt Lake City it was the first sign of civilization the army had seen since leaving Fort Leavenworth. Sunrise found the exhausted column at the gateway of the city wrapped in the foreboding silence of a graveyard.

Colonel R. T. Burton, Commander of the Nauvoo Legion contingent, watched the passing parade from the Beehive House, ready to fire the city if the army set up their quarters in the settlement. The order was never delivered as the soldier's camp fires were kindled on the other side of the Jordan River that night. Three days later they marched southward and established a permanent camp in Cedar Valley. The camp was called "Camp Floyd," after the Secretary of War. Thus, an unfortunate chapter in the history of the church, and of the State, was brought to a close. The army was maintained at Camp Floyd until the outbreak of the Civil War, when the camp was abandoned.

With pretended indifference to the army's presence, Brigham Young ordered the Saints to return to the northern settlements. "All who wish to return to their homes in Salt Lake City are at liberty to do so."¹³ The course taken by the Saints in the "Utah War" was vindicated in the eyes of the nation. It will ever remain one of the outstanding examples of the faith of a people in the power of the Almighty God to protect them. The unwavering position of Brigham Young that, with the help of the Lord, the Saints could withstand the entire Army of the United States, won the respect and admiration of the world. It will forever cause him to rank with the great spiritual leaders of the race.

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1. William E. Barrett, *The Restored Church*, (Salt Lake City, Utah: Deseret Book Company, 1969) Page 32
2. *Ibid.*, Page 322.
3. Donald R. Moorman, *Camp Floyd and The Mormons*, (Salt Lake City, Utah: University of Utah Press), Page 18.
4. William E. Barrett, *op. cit.*, p. 326.
5. *Ibid.*, Page 327.
6. *Ibid.*, p. 329.
7. *Cedar Stake Journal*, S.U.U. Special Collections Library, William R. Palmer Collection, F-12 & B-89, Cedar City, Utah.
8. "Cedar City L.D.S. Ward Relief Society Minute Book," December 10, 1857, Cedar City, Utah Regional Genealogy Library.
9. Andrew Jensen, *L.D.S. Journal History*, Entry for November 23, 1857, from *The New York Tribune*.
10. Isaac C. Haight, "Isaac C. Haight Journal," S.U.U. Special Collections Library, Box 88-F4, Cedar City, Utah.
11. Andrew Jensen, Cedar City Regional L.D.S. Genealogy Library, Film crmh 154.
12. *U. S. Soldiers Invade Utah*, S.U.U. Special Collections Library, F-826 & M-17, Cedar City, Utah, p. 215.
13. Donald R. Moorman, *op. cit.*, p. 55.

